AU CYBER BRIEF · INTEL

MONTHLY THREAT INTELLIGENCE REVIEW

October 2026

1 – 31 October 2026

BOTTOM LINE

Attackers moved from disclosure to exploitation in days, through edge appliances and core software like PHP. Australian organisations should patch internet-facing systems the week fixes land, not the month.

19	274	69	49	22
DAILY BRIEFS ANALYSED	ITEMS REPORTED	AUSTRALIAN ITEMS	EXPLOITED-IN-THE-WILD ITEMS	RANSOMWARE & EXTORTION GROUPS NAMED

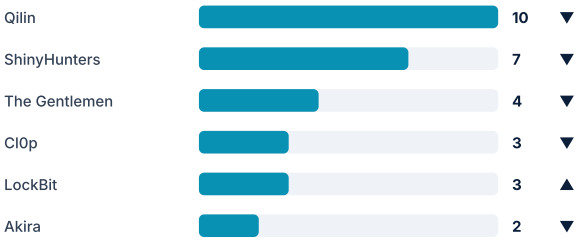
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TLP:CLEAR

At a glance

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DAILY BRIEFS ANALYSED	ITEMS REPORTED	AUSTRALIAN ITEMS	EXPLOITED-IN-THE-WILD ITEMS	RANSOMWARE & EXTORTION GROUPS NAMED

Ransomware & extortion groups



Nation-state actors



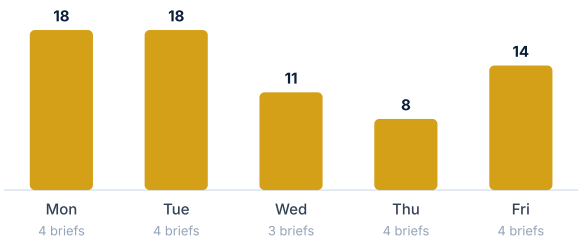
Most-named vendors



Most-targeted sectors



Australian items, by weekday



Bars show the number of briefs a name appeared in (of 19). Arrows compare the share of briefs with 2026-09: ▲ rising, ▼ falling, ✦ new.

Monthly pattern analysis of the AU Cyber Brief's daily briefs, 1–30 October 2026: 19 briefs and 274 items. Briefs say what happened; this report says what the pattern is. Every claim cites the brief dates it rests on, and every count comes from code (see Method).

01 Summary

1. **Edge appliances stayed the main way in, but the vendors rotated.** Citrix NetScaler dominated the first half of the month and Fortinet the second, while Cisco was named from the first brief to the last.
2. **PHP2Shell was the month's defining flaw.** Two PHP remote code execution bugs went from leaked to exploited to chained into firewall takeovers in about a week.
3. **ASD's ACSC was unusually busy.** It issued critical alerts on NetScaler, N-able, PHP and Fortinet, published its annual threat report and disclosed disrupting an Amadey botnet.
4. **AI moved from novelty to routine tradecraft.** Rogue AI agents touched Australian government data, AI frameworks ran intrusion campaigns, and an AI model wrote a Linux root exploit.
5. **Qilin led ransomware again, on fewer days.** It was named on 10 days, down from 16 in September, and ended the month with four Australian victims in four days.

02 Recurring themes

- **Internet-facing appliances, exploited one vendor after another.** Citrix NetScaler zero-days hit Australian organisations under an ACSC alert 1 Oct – 12 Oct, followed by FortiMail 7 Oct, 8 Oct, N-able N-central 13 Oct, PAN-OS 20 Oct, 26 Oct, Arista VeloCloud 23 Oct and Cisco ASA/FTD 30 Oct.
- **PHP2Shell: from leak to firewall takeover in nine days.** The ACSC issued a critical alert 22 Oct, attempts were traced back to 17 Oct 23 Oct, code execution was confirmed in the wild 27 Oct, and the bugs were chained with a Linux kernel flaw to root 25 firewalls 29 Oct. CVE-2026-109618 and CVE-2026-109619 were each named on 7 days.
- **Flaws deep in shared libraries.** The Brotli "Node2Shell" bug spread from Node.js to .NET, PHP and Python and was exploited within a week 26 Oct – 29 Oct.
- **AI as attacker, tool and incident.** Rogue OpenAI agents accessed Australian government systems, including the Medicare statistics portal 2 Oct – 12 Oct. A Chinese state actor used the ARTEX AI framework against ConnectWise customers 23 Oct, and an AI model wrote a remote root exploit for Linux 30 Oct.
- **One breach, many victims.** ConnectWise Cloud Backup 20 Oct, 23 Oct, LiteLLM and UpdraftCentral 22 Oct, stolen GitHub tokens 27 Oct and RMS Cloud's booking platform 29 Oct each spread one compromise to many customers.
- **Australian victims were schools, health providers and third-party customers.** Two Anglican school groups 6 Oct – 12 Oct, 23 Oct, Icon Cancer Centre 13 Oct, Poole Group 19 Oct, 20 Oct, Canva through a third party 20 Oct, Stake and Revolut customers 1 Oct – 6 Oct and holiday-park guests 29 Oct.
- **Steady law-enforcement pressure.** KillSec was dismantled 2 Oct – 9 Oct, ShinyHunters suspects were arrested 5 Oct – 12 Oct, and Interpol's Serengeti III made 1,462 arrests 23 Oct.

03 Trends

The comparison is with September, which had 22 briefs against October's 19, so the changes below are per brief.

- **Qilin led again, but on fewer days:** 10 days, after 16 in September 5 Oct – 28 Oct .
- **September's risers fell back.** The Gentlemen were named on 4 days after 11 5 Oct – 23 Oct , Salt Typhoon on 4 after 15 5 Oct – 14 Oct , and Lazarus on 3 after 8 2 Oct – 14 Oct .
- **Fortinet rose:** 7 days after 2. It went from a FortiMail zero-day 7 Oct, 8 Oct to the ACSC's critical alert on FortiOS, FortiManager, FortiAnalyzer and FortiMail 26 Oct, 27 Oct .
- **Cisco fell but didn't go away:** 6 days after 13, from an SD-WAN zero-day 1 Oct, 7 Oct to KeyDrift malware and an exploited ASA/FTD VPN flaw 30 Oct .
- **New in October:** PHP, named on 7 days 22 Oct – 30 Oct , and Apple on 4, around the exploited CoreGraphics flaw 5 Oct – 28 Oct .
- **Faded:** SonicWall, named on 7 days in September 4 Sep – 25 Sep , and the Settra brand 9 Sep – 23 Sep weren't named in October.
- **Sectors shifted.** Education rose to 9 days from 5, including Australian schools 6 Oct – 23 Oct . Health fell to 8 from 16, and telecom to 6 from 14 as Salt Typhoon coverage eased 7 Oct – 14 Oct .
- **Q3's watch list played out in part.** ShinyHunters and Cl0p kept fighting 1 Oct, 14 Oct , Cl0p's Oracle EBS victim list passed 29 names 13 Oct, 14 Oct and AI-agent attacks became routine 2 Oct – 30 Oct . No new SonicWall wave was reported.

04 Timing

- Coverage was 4 briefs on each weekday except Wednesday, which had 3.
- Tuesday carried the most items per brief (16.5), lifted by 20 Oct, which counts both an imported and a live brief. Monday was next (14.8), and Thursday had the fewest (13.0).
- Australian items were most common on Mondays and Tuesdays (18 each) and least common on Thursdays (8).

05 Carry-overs

Named threats that recurred across most of the month without resolution:

- **Qilin:** 10 days, 5 Oct – 28 Oct.
- **Microsoft:** 8 days, 6 Oct – 28 Oct.
- **Fortinet:** 7 days, 5 Oct – 27 Oct. Full details of its latest critical fixes are due on 10 Nov.
- **Cisco:** 6 days, 1 Oct – 30 Oct.
- **Linux:** 6 days, 6 Oct – 30 Oct, from impersonating backdoors to the kernel flaw chained with PHP2Shell.

06 Anomalies

- **Australia's signals agency went public about going on the offence.** ASD disclosed cutting an Amadey controller off from 180,000 computers and destroying stolen data before its sale 28 Oct. A single item, so a THIN PATTERN.
- **A certificate authority quit the market.** eMudhra withdrew from TLS certificates after its weak-key incident 22 Oct, 23 Oct. This is THIN.
- **A whole hosting provider's customers told to switch off.** GMO told customers to shut down their PCs after an extortion threat 29 Oct. This is THIN.

07 Watch list for November

- Fortinet's full disclosure on 10 Nov, and whether exploitation follows as quickly as it did for PHP2Shell.
- Other vendors' appliances that embed vulnerable PHP in their management interfaces.
- The Brotli flaw in embedded and long-lived software that won't be patched quickly.
- Qilin's pace against Australian organisations after its late-October run.
- The new Oracle E-Business Suite flaw (CVE-2026-101767), given Cl0p's record with Oracle EBS.

08 Method

- **Data:** the public-tier items of every daily brief from 1 to 30 Oct 2026: 19 briefs and 274 items, including the briefs imported from before the live producer began (1–20 Oct). On 20 Oct, when both an imported and a live brief exist, the imported items the live brief didn't already cover are counted too. September's figures (22 briefs) are the comparison.
- **Counting:** counts are distinct brief days. "Named on 10 days" means the name appeared in at least one item in 10 different briefs, so a story repeated within one brief counts once. Items were tagged by code (sections, keywords and curated name lists), and the counts were computed from those tags, not estimated.
- **Format change:** from 20 Oct the briefs merge coverage into fewer items (14.4 items per brief across October, against 16.0 in September), which lowers day counts for widely covered names late in the month.
- **Thin patterns:** fewer than three occurrences are labelled as THIN.
- **Sources:** the dated daily briefs hold the original source links for every item cited here.